

Rewiring Finance for a Warming World

Richard Clark and Noah Zucker*

July 2026

How do international organizations respond to emergent policy challenges? Focusing on the case of climate change, *Rewiring Finance for a Warming World* theorizes a process by which rank-and-file bureaucrats reallocate attention and effort across issue areas and affect high-level policy change. Individual staff become attentive to new challenges through their everyday work; IMF staff, for instance, encounter droughts, floods, and other climate disruptions while on regular missions overseas. Standard organizational practices, such as the rotation of staff between countries and internal teams, lead bureaucrats across an institution to devote greater effort to governing novel issues. Major policy reforms require the assent of institutional executives, who seek the support of both staff attentive to issues such as climate and powerful member states wary of mission drift. When peer institutions work on an emergent issue, staff and states supportive of mandate expansion can credibly threaten to take their labor and resources elsewhere, buttressing executives' support for reform. When few outside options exist, executives are more likely to side with skeptics and reject policy changes. We primarily test this argument at the International Monetary Fund, an institution with the potential to reshape global climate governance but one often regarded as ideologically rigid. Leading member states dismissed climate as orthogonal to the Fund's mission in 2008; within a decade, climate had nonetheless moved to the center of its operations. With original bureaucrat-level data, in-depth interview evidence, and case studies of other financial institutions, we show how staff learn, debate one another, and navigate fractious political environments to remake their institutions for an era of climate crisis.

* Clark: Associate Professor of Political Science, University of Notre Dame (richard.clark@nd.edu).
Zucker: Assistant Professor of Politics, Princeton University (noahzucker@princeton.edu).